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Source: *Gregorianum*, 2011, Vol. 92, No. 3 (2011), pp. 517-532

Published by: Edizioni Studium srl

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/43922415>

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Transposing Theology into the Categories of Meaning

In his work, *The Eucharist*, Edward Schillebeeckx sought to transpose traditional Catholic doctrine on the Eucharistic presence of Christ, expressed in terms of transubstantiation, into a different set of categories based on meaning, so as to speak of the Eucharistic change as a transignification or a transfinalization.¹ In doing so Schillebeeckx sought to overcome the supposed limitations of a substance-based metaphysics and adopt a more anthropological framework which better communicated the reality of the Eucharistic change to a contemporary audience. While laudable in his goals the official Church response to this proposal was not a happy one. Indeed Pope Paul VI issued an encyclical on the Eucharist, *Mysterium Fidei*, in which he explicitly criticized those theologians who spoke of the Eucharistic change as «nothing more than ‘transignification’ or ‘transfinalization’ as they call it»,² adding that «everyone can see that the spread of these and similar opinions does great harm to belief in and devotion to the Eucharist».³ It was not that he was arguing that there was not a change in meaning or value, but that these changes arose because of a change in the Eucharistic substance.⁴ For Paul VI a change in meaning alone did not constitute a changed reality, but was just something in us, in our «mind», whereas the Eucharistic change was «real», or as his Credo of the People of God states it, it occurs «independently of our mind».⁵ To some extent such a framework was also adopted by Schillebeeckx himself who struggled to express any intrinsic relationship between reality and meaning, hovering uneasily between Platonic and Kantian modes of idealism.⁶

¹ E. SCHILLEBEECKX, *The Eucharist*, New York, 1968.

² *Mysterium Fidei*, n. 11.

³ *Ibid.*, n. 12

⁴ *Ibid.*, n.46.

⁵ Paul VI, *Credo of the People of God*, n.25.

⁶ Schillebeeckx's starting point is the distinction between the *noumenon* and the *phenomenon* (E. SCHILLEBEECKX, *The Eucharist*, 107). However, while the language is Kantian, his own position is more Platonic in that it posits an accessible intelligibility to the noumena. His later work, however, moves more in a Kantian position. See N. ORMEROD, «Schillebeeckx's Philosophic Prolegomenon: A Dialectic Analysis» in W. DANAHER (ed.), *Australian Lonergan Workshop*, Lanham (Md), 1993, 69-78.

This excursus into recent theological history serves to remind us of the struggle faced by Catholic theologians in the era of *ressourcement* and *aggiornamento* at the time of Vatican II. Scholasticism was deemed passé, but what was to replace it? Should it be replaced by biblical language, or existential or anthropological categories? Much of the Catholic Church's doctrinal legacy was expressed in the metaphysical categories of the scholastics so theology would be faced with a massive task of transposition of this legacy into a different mode of expression, whichever way one chooses to go. Would such a transposition faithfully render the truths of the doctrinal legacy or would their meaning be changed by such a transposition? Clearly Paul VI was of the opinion that Schillebeeckx's efforts at transposition did not faithfully render the content of the tradition on the Eucharistic presence.

Distinct from the question of the type of language and categories one should adopt, and to some extent masked by that question, lies the deeper issue of the control of meaning for whatever language or set of categories one did adopt. The apparent uniformity of scholasticism on metaphysics glossed over significant conflicts on various issues.⁷ Schillebeeckx's foray into the categories of meaning highlighted unresolved problems there as well, in his inability to articulate a clear relationship between these new categories and the older metaphysical categories of substance and accident. Without a critical control of meaning earlier disputes would simply be carried over into the new framework without resolution.

Despite the difficulties encountered by Schillebeeckx in his attempted transposition I would like to suggest that categories of meaning provide a sound theological option for a transposition of the achievements of the past, both doctrinal and theological. However, such a transposition will need a more secure base than that provided by Schillebeeckx. That base can be found in the work of Bernard Lonergan whose approach to questions of meaning will be explored below. Not only does Lonergan provide a much richer account of meaning than that deployed by Schillebeeckx and others, he also offers a control of meaning for that account based on his exposition of human interiority. This allows for the development of a full blown «ontology of meaning» which can overcome the types of concerns expressed by Paul VI in his treatment of transignification and transfinalization.

In this present paper I shall provide a summary of Lonergan's account of meaning drawn largely from his work, *Method in Theology*. I shall then consider three theological areas which would positively benefit from a transposition

⁷ As Lonergan notes, «the broad agreement of scholastics in metaphysics is matched by an equally broad agreement in epistemology, and the divergence of scholastic views in epistemology is matched by the no less impressive array of disputed questions in metaphysics» (B. LONERGAN, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, in F.E. CROWE – R.M. DORAN [eds], *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 3, Toronto, 1992, 21-22).

into the categories that Lonergan provides: the theology of revelation; Trinity and Incarnation; and church and sacraments. This will seek to demonstrate the utility of such a transposition for theology more generally. A fuller transposition is a more remote goal, but one might hope that the present offering is enough to be indicative of the value of the exercise.

Lonergan and the categories of meaning

Lonergan discusses the question of meaning in his two major works, *Insight* and *Method in Theology*.⁸ As always his work is complex and there are signs of development and enrichment in his thought on the topic of meaning, and so it will not be possible to give a thorough account here.⁹ However throughout it all the starting point for Lonergan in this area, as it is for all his work, is human interiority. And so the focus is not on the outer word, utterance or sentence, but on the inner word which is uttered interiorly by the speaker. «The inner word is what is meant immediately by the outer [word]». ¹⁰ It is an important reminder that meaning exists primarily in persons, in hearts and minds, and only secondarily in what is said, written or otherwise expressed. Indeed far from limiting «expression» to the spoken or written work, Lonergan identifies five distinct «carriers of meaning»: intersubjective, artistic, symbolic, literary, and incarnate carriers all of which in different ways express the «inner word».

Intersubjective Meaning

Spontaneous intersubjectivity arises from a vital and functional identification with the other. This identification precedes the distinction of subjects into «I» and «Thou», and even the «We» of mutual love. One aspect of this intersubjectivity is the intersubjective communication of meaning. By illustrating this point with a brief phenomenology of the smile, Lonergan stresses that intersubjective meaning «is not about some object. Rather, it reveals or even betrays the subject, and the revelation is immediate». ¹¹

Artistic Meaning

Following Susanne Langer, Lonergan defines art as «the objectification of a purely experiential pattern». A work of art is a concrete pattern of the internal relations of, say, colors, tones, volumes, movements, and so forth. It is a

⁸ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology*, New York, 1971.

⁹ In what follows I follow R.M. DORAN, *Theology and the Dialectics of History*, Toronto, 1990, especially Chapters 18 and 19.

¹⁰ B. LONERGAN, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, in F.E. CROWE – R.M. DORAN (eds), *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 2, Toronto, 1997, 14.

¹¹ B. LONERGAN, *Method*, 59-61.

pure pattern in as much as it excludes patterns that instrumentalize experience. The meaning of art is elemental: the meaning and the meant are not distinguished. As art transforms the world, so too the subject who experiences it is transformed. Liberated from the routine structuring of existence, the artist «becomes just himself: emergent, ecstatic, originating freedom».¹²

Symbolic Meaning

Lonergan defines a symbol as «an image of a real or imaginary object that evokes a feeling or is evoked by a feeling». Given the link Lonergan establishes between feelings and values,¹³ our developing moral sensitivity (or its distortion) will involve a «transvaluation and transformation of symbols». Symbols neither obey the laws of logic nor «bow to the principle of excluded middle», preferring to overwhelm the opponent rather than merely prove a point. Prior to logic and dialectic, symbols can express «what logical discourse abhors: the existence of internal tensions, incompatibilities, conflicts, struggles, destructions».¹⁴

Linguistic Meaning

In language, Lonergan argues, meaning finds its greatest liberation. The conventional signs of language can be multiplied almost indefinitely. While Lonergan has consistently maintained the pre-linguistic nature of the act of understanding, he nonetheless acknowledges the power of language to advance understanding. «So it is that conscious intentionality develops in and is moulded by its mother tongue. It is not merely that we learn the names of what we see but also that we can attend to and talk about the things that we can name».¹⁵

Incarnate meaning

Lonergan introduces this notion by referring to John Henry Newman's motto, *cor ad cor loquitur*. Incarnate meaning is «the meaning of a person, of his way of life, of his words, or of his deeds». It can thus combine intersubjective, artistic, symbolic, and linguistic carriers of meaning. Meaning occurs as incarnate in its significance, say, for another person, or more widely, for a group, a nation or a social, cultural or religious tradition.¹⁶

And so Lonergan presents a wide variety of ways in which meaning is carried forward into human communities. But whatever the form of expression, the sources of meaning «are all conscious acts and all intended contents, whether in the dream state or on any of the four levels of waking consciousness».¹⁷

¹² *Ibid.*, 61-64.

¹³ Lonergan speaks of feelings in terms of intentional responses to value (*Ibid.*, 30-34).

¹⁴ *Ibid.*, 64-69.

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 71.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 73.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, 73.

Lonergan's notion of levels of consciousness then leads to his distinction between different elements of meaning, as potential, formal, full, constitutive and effective acts of meaning.¹⁸ Potential acts are those where meaning and meant are not yet distinct, as in the smile, the symbol or even in the act of insight itself. Lonergan refers to such meaning as elemental. Formal acts are acts of «conceiving, thinking, considering, defining, supposing, formulating» where meaning and meant are distinguished. Full acts are acts of judging what is or is not the case, while effective and constitutive acts include «judgments of value, decisions, actions».¹⁹

What Lonergan means by the distinction between constitutive and effective acts of meaning is clarified when he speaks of the different «functions of meaning», i.e. meaning as cognitive, effective, constitutive, and communicative. The *cognitive function* of meaning works to take us beyond the child's world of the immediately given and experienced, into the adult's world – the world mediated by meaning. This larger world does not lie within anyone's immediate experience. It is the reality of what is intended in questions. It encompasses a world of objective truth determined not only by experience, but by potential, formal and full acts of meaning.²⁰

The *effective function* of meaning relates to the world of human activity: «Men work. But their work is not mindless. What we make, we first intend». Through the effective function of meaning we enter a world of planning, of investigating possibilities, of weighing pros and cons, of entering into contracts, of orders given and received: «The whole of that added, man-made, artificial world is the cumulative, now planned, now chaotic, product of human acts of meaning».²¹

The *constitutive function* of meaning is found in the intrinsically meaningful component of social and cultural institutions. Such institutions – religions, art-forms, languages, sciences, philosophies, histories – are «inextricably involved in acts of meaning». Moreover, changes in such institutions are often brought about by a change in meaning: «a change of idea or concept, a change of judgment or evaluation, a change of the order or request». An apposite example of such change is the reinterpretation of a national constitution.²²

The *communicative function* of meaning is shown in the actual communication of one person to another, in any or all of the intersubjective, artistic, symbolic, linguistic or incarnate modes. Through the communicative function,

¹⁸ While the language has some similarity to metaphysical terms such as potency, form and act, the parallel is misleading, because each of these is an «act» of meaning, and so as an act has its own potency, form and act. This is one of the main points of Doran, *Theology and the Dialectics of History*, Chap 19.

¹⁹ B. LONERGAN, *Method*, 74.

²⁰ *Ibid.*, 76-77.

²¹ *Ibid.*, 77-78.

²² *Ibid.*, 78.

meaning can become a rich store of common meaning to attain, if successfully communicated, social and historical significance.²³

Indeed, for Lonergan, the communicative and constitutive functions of meaning taken together give us notions of community, existence and history. For community is an achievement of common meaning. Such meaning is merely potential in shared experience; it becomes formal in common understandings, and actual in common judgments, to be fully realised through common decisions and choices. Into such communities people are born; and it is only with respect to a community's common meanings that the individual «grows in experience, understanding, judgment and so comes to find out for himself that he has to decide for himself what to make of himself».²⁴ Thus there arises the notion of existence, which, in its turn, may be authentic or inauthentic: «There is the minor authenticity or unauthenticity of the subject with respect to the tradition that nourishes him. There is the major authenticity that justifies or condemns the tradition itself».²⁵ When the tradition itself is unauthentic one may find that one «can do no more than authentically realize unauthenticity». It is left to history and divine providence to pass judgment on all traditions.²⁶

As meaning is prolonged into historical timeframes Lonergan adds to his discussion notions of «realms» and «stages» of meaning. He identifies five realms of meaning, as commonsense, theory, interiority, transcendence, scholarship and art.²⁷ These find their source in corresponding differentiations of consciousness of the human subject. Such differentiations and their corresponding realms are not just given but emerge both individually and historically.²⁸ Similarly Lonergan's three stages of meaning are historical «ideal types» for understanding the emergence of different realms in history. So the first stage is that of undifferentiated common sense. The second is the emergence of theory, which is then placed in tension with the world of common sense. That tension is resolved in the third stage of meaning with the emergence of an interior realm which critically relates and differentiates the realms of common sense and theory (and scholarship and art).

This is a very rich account of meaning and is suggestive of a large number of theological applications. Elsewhere I have suggested their utility in providing a more explanatory discussion of the problem of continuity and disconti-

²³ *Ibid.*, 78-9.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 79.

²⁵ *Ibid.*, 80.

²⁶ *Ibid.*, 80.

²⁷ Initially in *Method* Lonergan speaks of four realms, commonsense, theory, interiority and transcendence (*Ibid.*, 81-85). He later adds a realm of scholarship and art (*Ibid.*, 272).

²⁸ For example the work of C. TAYLOR, *Sources of the Self: The Making of the Modern Identity*, Cambridge (Mass.), 1989, can be viewed as mapping out the emergence of the interior realm of meaning from the time of Descartes to the present era.

nuity at Vatican II.²⁹ Here I will explore the areas of the theologies of revelation; of Trinity and Incarnation; and of Church and sacraments.

*Theology of revelation*³⁰

Perhaps the most common way of speaking of revelation in contemporary theology is in terms of divine self-communication. Such discussions take their lead from the Dogmatic Constitution on Divine Revelation, *Dei Verbum*, which speaks of revelation not in terms of information about God, but a giving of God's own self in revelation.³¹ Following the lead of Karl Rahner and others this self-revelation came to be called a genuine self-communication whereby God communicates God's own being to us. Gerald O'Collins has suggested that Pope John Paul II made his own this particular form of speaking about revelation.³²

Through the influence of Rahner's theology much of this divine self-communication has been conceived metaphysically in terms of a quasi-formal causality.³³ Whatever the strengths and weaknesses of this approach a more natural entry point might be to think of such communication in the categories of meaning. For what is communicated in revelation is meaning(ful). God's word to us is not just «sound and fury signifying nothing», but full of meaning, that is, meaning-full communication. Indeed Lonergan speaks of revelation explicitly in terms of the entry of divine meaning into human history.³⁴ If divine meaning enters into human history then two immediate questions we can ask are, «How is this meaning carried into human history?» and «How does it function within human history?»

In terms of the carriers of divine meaning, there is no a prior reason why any of the carriers of meaning identified by Lonergan should not be considered as potential carriers of divine meaning. And so if one were to focus attention on the Bible one would speak of linguistic carriers of meaning; one can explore what realms of meaning find expression in Scripture. In particular one might conclude that the Scriptures operate within a commonsense realm of

²⁹ N. ORMEROD, «Vatican II - Continuity or Discontinuity? Toward an Ontology of Meaning» in *Theological Studies* 71 (2010) 609-636.

³⁰ The material in this section is drawn from a fuller study, N. ORMEROD, *Method, Meaning and Revelation: The Meaning and Function of Revelation in Bernard Lonergan's Method in Theology*, Lanham (MD), 2000.

³¹ «In His goodness and wisdom God chose to reveal Himself» (see *Dei Verbum*, n. 2).

³² G. O'COLLINS, «The Pope's Theology» in *The Tablet*, 27 June 1992, 246.

³³ K. RAHNER, *Foundations of Christian Faith: An Introduction to the Idea of Christianity*, New York, 1982, 116-33.

³⁴ «For revelation is God's entry into man's making of man, and so theology not only has to reflect on revelation, but also it has somehow to mediate *God's meaning into the whole of human affairs*» (B. LONERGAN, «Theology in Its New Context» in W. RYAN - B. TYRRELL [eds], *Second Collection*, Philadelphia, 1974, 62. Emphasis added).

meaning rather than a technical realm, and so avoid the mistake of seeking technical solutions to technical problems through references to the Scriptures, whether this be a matter of seeking answers to scientific questions from the Bible, or the use of Scripture as a source of proof texts.

On the other hand, the work of Avery Dulles might focus our attention on symbolic carriers of meaning,³⁵ while Hans Urs von Balthasar³⁶ and Robert Doran³⁷ might focus more on artistic carriers of meaning. Doran seems to prioritise elemental meanings, that is carriers where meaning and meant are not distinct, such as intersubjective, artistic and symbolic meanings as «closest to the forms of divine revelation itself».³⁸ Such carriers are capable of «inexhaustible meaning».³⁹ In particular Doran has in mind the revelation of redemption in the Christ-event.

The affirmed truth of the redemption, the doctrine of redemption, lies rather in the domain of *permanently elemental meaning*. That is to say, it is possible that its meaning will always be better expressed in the symbolic, aesthetic, and/or dramatic terms of scripture, literature, and drama, and be lived forward from the narrative, than it will be formulated in the quasi-technical type of formulation that most dogmas provide.⁴⁰

He argues that the truth of the doctrine of redemption «is primarily what Balthasar calls the truth of a divine *deed*».⁴¹ This meaning can never be contained or captured within a conceptual frame, because, to quote Lonergan, «The proper expression of the elemental meaning is the work of art itself».⁴²

While I agree with Doran that such elemental carriers of meaning are «first for us» I think a case can be made that what is «first in itself» in terms of carriers of meaning is what Lonergan refers to as «incarnate meaning». The ontologically prior carriers of divine meaning are those grace-filled authentic subjects (prophets and saints) whose lives radiate divine meaning through their love of God and their neighbors. As authentic subjects engaged in human history, and making use of a range of others carriers of meaning such as intersubjective, artistic, symbolic and linguistic, they reveal God's will for humanity through their own participation in the divine life. Theirs is a genuine par-

³⁵ A. DULLES, *Models of Revelation*, Maryknoll (N.Y.), 1992.

³⁶ H.U. VON BALTHASAR, *Seeing the Form*, trans. Erasmo Leiva-Merikakis, vol. 1, *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics*, San Francisco - New York, 1983. For a summary account see J.J. O'DONNELL, *Hans Urs Von Balthasar*, London, 1992, 18-34.

³⁷ R.M. DORAN, *What Is Systematic Theology?*, Toronto, 2006.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, 28.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, 123.

⁴⁰ *Ibid.*, 22. Emphasis in the original.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 22. Emphasis in the original.

⁴² B. LONERGAN, *Method*, 67. It is perhaps worth noting the importance of liturgy in such an understanding, particularly the Easter liturgy as an opportunity to immerse oneself in this elemental meaning.

ticipation in divine meaning through the life of grace. And just as Rahner posits a searching Christology,⁴³ so too we can ask whether incarnate meaning can be such as to be identical with divine meaning? Can a human being carry divine meaning to such an extent as to actually be a divine person? These questions take us into Trinitarian and Christological doctrine and theology, which I consider more fully below.

We can also ask how divine meaning functions within human history. Traditionally great emphasis has been placed on the cognitional function of revelation, particularly the truth of doctrine. However, one needs to also attend to the constitutive, effective and communicative function of revelation. Revelation is constitutive of the Church as a community of shared meanings. This aspect of revelation has been emphasized by George Lindbeck when he speaks of doctrine as «cultural-linguistic». So for Lindbeck, within a religious community, «its doctrines, cosmic stories or myths, and ethical directives are integrally related to the rituals it practices, the sentiments or experiences it evokes, the actions it recommends and the institutional forms it develops».⁴⁴ In this way revelation functions to establish the religious identity of the community and is reminiscent of what Wittgenstein called a «language game».⁴⁵ On a more negative note Lindbeck seems to deny any determinative cognitive function for doctrines, adopting an agnosticism in relation to their truth claims. Others, such as the early writings of Gregory Baum, have emphasized more the effective function of revelation, its transformative impact on a way of life.⁴⁶ Revelation commits us to a new way of living and relating to the world. Finally there is a communicative function of revelation. As Pope John XXIII reminded us, there is a genuine distinction to be made between the meaning of doctrines and the way that meaning is expressed or communicated. The communication of revelation needs to be intelligible to the audience who receives it, and so the same truths may be communicated in different ways to different audiences, depending on the needs and context of the times. And so the early Councils transposed the truths of the New Testament into thought-forms that communicated to a more philosophically informed culture of the Roman Empire. Further Schillebeeckx's attempt to transpose the ways in which Catholic belief in the real presence were expressed was in part motivated by a sense that the old language simply no longer communicated to the context of the day. He notes that the aim of the theologian is «to make the

⁴³ K. RAHNER, *Foundations*, 295.

⁴⁴ George A. LINDBECK, *The Nature of Doctrine: Religion and Theology in a Postliberal Age*, Philadelphia, 1984, 33.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*.

⁴⁶ As Dulles notes, for Baum, revelation «is not information about the divine, to be intellectually assimilated. It is rather, salvational truth [...] it constitutes a new awareness in man through which he sees the world in a new light and commits himself to a new kind of action» (A. DULLES, *Models of Revelation*, 101).

mystery or the dogma of faith *speak* to us in our life here and now». ⁴⁷ The problem Schillebeeckx seems to be identifying is primarily one of communicative meaning, given shifts in culture over historical periods of time. ⁴⁸

There are further questions that could be asked in relation to the impact of revelation in history and Lonergan's construct of stages of meaning. For example Pope John Paul II argues that «Revelation therefore introduces into our history a universal and ultimate truth which stirs the human mind to ceaseless effort; indeed it impels reason continually to extend the range of its knowledge until it sense that it has done all in its power, leaving no stone unturned». ⁴⁹ Further this process of inculturation has a particular impact on the Greek philosophical tradition. «The Church cannot abandon what she has gained from her inculturation in the world of Greco-Latin thought. To reject this heritage would be to deny the providential plan of God who guides the Church down the paths of time and history». ⁵⁰ Such a suggestion could fruitfully be examined in terms of Lonergan's notion of stages of meaning and the impact of revelation in bringing about a shift in stages. However, at this point it might be enough to conclude that a transposition of the theology of revelation into the categories of meaning provided by Lonergan is extremely fruitful and suggestive of further theological investigations. It has already been suggested by these investigation that certain Christological questions naturally arise. To these we now turn.

Trinity and incarnation

Both Karl Barth and Karl Rahner posited strong links between the theology of revelation and the doctrine of the Trinity. For Barth belief in Trinity was expressed in terms of Revealer, Revealed and Revealedness of God. ⁵¹ For Rahner the divine self-communication was expressed through the two proces-

⁴⁷ E. SCHILLEBEECKX, *The Eucharist*, 17. Emphasis in the original.

⁴⁸ More forcefully, in his later work Schillebeeckx argues, «earlier expressions of faith, even dogmas, are on the one hand irrevocable and irreversible: they cannot be done away with, since with a particular social and cultural system of reference they have time and again expressed and sought to safeguard the mystery of Jesus Christ [...] in a way which is sometimes more and sometimes less successful for that time. But on the other hand, in their cultural and historical forms they can become irrelevant and indeed meaningless for later generations as they are simply repeated as they stand, because earlier generations expressed their deepest convictions about Christian faith within another semantic field, in another system of communication, and through a different perspective on reality» (E. SCHILLEBEECKX, *Church: The Human Story of God*, trans. John Bowden, New York, 1990, 43).

⁴⁹ *Fides et ratio* n. 14.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, n. 72. For an analysis of this issue see N. ORMEROD, «Faith and Reason: Perspectives from MacIntyre and Lonergan» in *Heythrop Journal* 46 (2005) 11-22.

⁵¹ For an exposition of Barth's theology see J.J. O'DONNELL, *The Mystery of the Triune God*, London, 1988, 18-24.

sions of Word and Spirit prolonged into human history. Rahner will go so far as to say that in some sense only a Trinitarian God can communicate Godself into human history.⁵² In itself the doctrine of the Trinity is a belief in a three-fold distinction of Persons, Father, Son and Spirit, within the one Godhead, with these Persons related via two processions. Belief in the Incarnation refers then to the belief that the Second Person of the Trinity, the Son or Word, entered into human history as a human being, known as Jesus of Nazareth. How then might these beliefs be transposed into the types of categories provided by Lonergan's account of meaning?

I shall begin by adopting the broad outline of the psychological analogy initiated by Augustine in *De Trinitate*, refined by Aquinas in the *Summa Theologiae*, and further developed by Lonergan.⁵³ Because this analogy draws upon inner cognitive and volitional acts, it is not difficult to reframe these in terms of the categories of meaning outlined above.⁵⁴ In the first instance the Word can be thought of analogously as the formal and full act of meaning of the Father. As Lonergan notes, while in us conception (formal act) and judgment (full act) are distinct, in the infinite being of God they are identical.⁵⁵ Further the Son can also be thought of as analogous to a judgment of value, a *verbum spirans amorem* (ST, Ia, q. 43, a. 5), in this case a constitutive judgment of value.⁵⁶ Similarly the Spirit can be thought of analogously as a decision flowing from the judgment of value, a decisive constitutive act of loving meaning of the Father and Son. These meaning acts of Son and Spirit are then made effective in human history through the two divine missions. In the Incarnation the divine formal, full and constitutive act of meaning that is the Son is given human expression through the diverse carriers of meaning, as intersubjective, artistic, symbolic, literary and most importantly, incarnate. Jesus does not simply speak God's Word, his personal identity is that of God's Word incarnate amongst us (John 1:14). The sources of these meanings in history are the conscious intentional acts of the incarnate Word, Jesus Christ, whose own experience of the Father is elemental or potential,

⁵² K. RAHNER, *The Trinity*, New York, 1997, 99-101, where Rahner «deduces» the immanent Trinity from the event of an economic self-communication.

⁵³ B. LONERGAN, *De Deo Trino, Pars Systematica*, Rome, 1964. This work is now available in English translation as B. LONERGAN, *The Triune God: Systematics*, trans. Michael Shields, in R.M. DORAN – D. MONSOUR (eds), *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 12, Toronto, 2007. For a defence of the continuing relevance of the psychological analogy see N. ORMEROD, «The Psychological Analogy for the Trinity – at Odds with Modernity» in *Pacifica* 14 (2001) 281-94.

⁵⁴ See for example B. LONERGAN, *The Triune God: Systematics*. Also N. ORMEROD, *Trinity: Retrieving the Western Tradition*, Milwaukee, 2005.

⁵⁵ B. LONERGAN, *Verbum*, 204-208, but especially 208.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.* In fact for Lonergan the judgment of value becomes the prime analogue for the procession of the Son. See B. LONERGAN, *The Triune God: Systematics*, 181-89; B. LONERGAN, «Christology Today: Methodological Reflections» in F. CROWE (ed.), *A Third Collection*, New York, 1985, 93.

that is, where meaning is not distinguished from meant, in the beatific vision.⁵⁷ That potential divine meaning is given formal, full, constitutive, and effective expression in the life, death and resurrection of Jesus. That divine meaning functions cognitively as an expression of divine meaning and truth through the faith of believers; constitutively through Christ alive in believers (Gal 2:20) and in the Holy Spirit poured into our hearts (Rom 5:5);⁵⁸ communicatively in the preaching of Jesus and the Apostles and the literary documents of the New Testament; and effectively in the ongoing mission of the Church prolonging the mission of Jesus and empowered by his Spirit. The constitutive and communicative functions give rise to the community, existence and history of the Church.

This admittedly compressed account again demonstrates the ways in which categories of meaning provided by Lonergan can be integrated into traditional theological themes and shed new light on them. In particular what is gained in this transposition is a seamless integration of the theology of the immanent and economic Trinity. One of the constant criticisms of the psychological analogy, for example, is its remoteness from our experience of the economic Trinity.⁵⁹ By transposing the psychological analogy into the categories of meaning and viewing the divine missions in terms of their effective role in human history the connections between our theologies of the immanent Trinity and economic Trinity become transparent. The same acts of meaning which constitute the identities of the Son and Spirit in the immanent Trinity become effective acts of meaning entering into human history through their divine missions experienced as the economic Trinity. In this way we can find a more positive meaning to Rahner's axiom identifying the immanent and economic Trinity.⁶⁰

Church and sacraments

We have already spoken above of the Church as a community of shared meanings that arise out of the communication of divine meaning into human history, through the missions of the divine Word and Spirit. In particular we can speak of Jesus' words and actions in the Last Supper as an effective act of meaning which creates a new covenant between God and human beings, a covenant realized in

⁵⁷ Hence the content of the beatific vision is ineffable, or incommunicable. See B. LONERGAN, *De Verbo Incarnato*, Rome, ³1964, 332-416.

⁵⁸ And so Aquinas speaks of the indwelling of both Word and Spirit. See *Summa Theologiae*, Ia, q. 43, a. 5, esp ad. 2.

⁵⁹ See N. ORMEROD, «The Psychological Analogy for the Trinity», 284-87, for a summary of contemporary critiques of the analogy.

⁶⁰ K. RAHNER, *The Trinity*, 21-4. For a critique of the axiom on other grounds see Dennis W. Jowers, «A Test of Karl Rahner's Axiom, "the Economic Trinity Is the Immanent Trinity and Vice Versa"» in *Thomist* 70 (2006) 421-55; N. ORMEROD, «Wrestling with Rahner on the Trinity» in *Irish Theological Quarterly* 68 (2003) 213-27.

the life of the Church. Jesus' actions effect a new reality in a human history constituted by meaning. The Church carries forward divine meanings through the various carriers of meanings (intersubjective, symbolic, artistic, linguistic, and incarnate), expressed beautifully by John Henry Newman in the following terms:

I think I am right in saying that the tradition of the Apostles, committed to the whole Church in its various constituents and functions *per modum unius*, manifests itself variously at various times: sometimes by the mouth of the episcopacy, sometimes by the doctors [i.e. theologians], sometimes by the people, sometimes by liturgies, rites, ceremonies, and customs, by events, disputes, movements, and all other phenomena which are comprised under the name of history.⁶¹

Those meanings function cognitively as a set of beliefs held as true; constitutively as creating the identity of the Church through shared beliefs, rites, customs, art, ceremonies, and a common life together, and effectively as motivating the mission of the Church which

offers a force for liberation which promotes development precisely because it leads to conversion of heart and way of thinking, fosters the recognition of each person's dignity, encourages solidarity, commitment and service of one's neighbour, and gives everyone a place in God's plan, which is the building of his Kingdom of peace, justice, beginning already in this life (*Redemptoris missio*, n. 59).

Finally those meanings function communicatively in the preaching and witness of the Church. That witness in particular speaks powerfully of the divine meaning realized as incarnate meaning in the lives of men and women who are transformed by their love of God, their union with the divine Word and the indwelling of his Spirit.

As meaningful events the theology of the sacraments can also be similarly transposed. Ritual actions of the liturgy can be considered in terms of the intersubjective, symbolic and artistic carriers of meaning. In this sense the meaning of liturgy is primarily elemental, where meaning is not distinguished from the meant. Such meaning engages the whole person and is potentially transformative, because, as Lonergan notes of symbolic meaning, «it is through symbols that mind and body, mind and heart, heart and body communicate».⁶² As such these elemental meanings can mediate liberation from the aberrations which lead to various forms of bias. And so the meaning carried by liturgical ritual functions effectively to mediate the divine meaning they symbolize. However this meaning also functions constitutively as these rituals are constitutive of the identity of the Church. They express what it means to be part of this historical Church community.

⁶¹ J.H. NEWMAN, *On Consulting the Faithful in Matters of Doctrine*, London, 1961, 63.

⁶² B. LONERGAN, *Method*, 67.

Does speaking of sacraments in terms of effective and constitutive meaning fall into the concerns raised by Paul VI that such meanings are merely «subjective»? As Giovanni Sala has indicated this might be so if these categories of meaning had no ontological significance.⁶³ However, effective and constitutive meanings are «real», because our human world is constituted by such meanings. Constitutions really do help constitute a state and a change of that constitution, or its reinterpretation, creates a real change in the state. A contract between two parties effects a reality between them, with real responsibilities and consequences for both. To speak of the sacraments in the categories of meaning is not to make them subjective, rather it locates them within a human world of meaning, as carriers of the divine meaning we call grace, constituting the life of the Church and effecting conversion from sin.⁶⁴ Rather than opposing an ontological approach to an approach based on meaning, as is proposed by Louis-Marie Chauvet,⁶⁵ what is required is a developed ontology of meaning. Joseph Martos has suggested that in the process of such a transposition some traditional elements of a scholastic theology of the sacraments may fall away, such as the notion of *sacramentum et res*.⁶⁶ Such a conclusion requires further investigation, but it raises the same issues we witnessed in relation to Schillebeeckx's transposition of Eucharistic doctrine into the categories of meaning. What is central to the tradition, and what has simply developed as a mode of expressing a particular belief within a framework of meaning that no longer communicates to people?

The notion of an ontology of meaning has larger implications. If the Church as a historical community is a community of shared meanings, then the unfolding history of that community can be analyzed in terms of the movement of meanings over historical timeframes. We then realize that the problem of

⁶³ G. SALA, «Transsubstantiation Oder Transsignifikation: Gedanken Zu Einem Dilemma» in *Zeitschrift für Katholische Theologie* 92 (1970) 1-34. For a summary of the debate see P. BEER, «"Transsubstantiation Oder Transsignifikation?": Giovanni Sala and Edward Schillebeeckx on the Eucharistic Presence» in W. DANAHER (ed.), *Australian Loneran Workshop*, Lanham, 1993, 47-68.

⁶⁴ In a recent paper presented at West Coast Method Institute (2010) at Loyola Marymount (LA), Joseph Mudd (Boston College) identified a number of Irish Jesuits, who under the influence of Loneran, have sought to effect such a shift into the categories of meaning. These include P. MCSHANE, «On the Causality of the Sacraments» in *Theological Studies* 24 (1963) 423-36; B. MCNAMARA, «Christus Patiens in Mass and Sacraments: Higher Perspectives» in *Irish Theological Quarterly* 42 (1975) 17-35; J. McDERMOTT, «The Sacramental Vision of Loneran's *Grace and Freedom*» in *Sapientia* 50 (1995) 115-48; R. MOLONEY, *The Eucharist*, Collegeville (Minn.), 1995.

⁶⁵ L.-M. CHAUVET, *Symbol and Sacrament: A Sacramental Reinterpretation of Christian Existence*, trans. Patrick Madigan and Madeleine Beaumont, Collegeville (Minn.), 1995. Chauvet contrasts his linguistic approach with what he calls onto-theology. However, his approach is not simply linguistic; as I read him, «linguistic» stands for a variety of carriers of meaning, not just language.

⁶⁶ J. MARTOS, *The Sacraments: An Interdisciplinary and Interactive Study*, Collegeville (Minn.), 2009, 2-3, 130-34.

transposing meanings from one «language» to another is not new. The early Church transposed the meanings of the Gospels into the philosophical language of the Greco-Roman empire. Did this transposition remain faithful to the Gospel or did it rather undermine the pure spirit of the Gospel with Greek philosophy, as proposed by Adolf Harnack?⁶⁷ This transposition was itself transposed into technical metaphysical meanings in the era of Scholasticism. In our own day new transpositions are emerging and in each case the same question occurs – is this faithful to the tradition? Indeed it is possible to read John Henry Newman's *The Development of Doctrine* as an exercise in the ontology of meaning seeking to explicate the ways in which meaning develops over time as either a genuine development or a corruption of the tradition.⁶⁸ To consider the Church as an unfolding historical community is to inevitably be caught up in questions of meaning.

Conclusion

I began this article with some comments on the efforts of Schillebeeckx to transpose traditional belief in the Eucharistic presence into the categories of meaning. Whatever the reservations that may have been expressed at the time the impulse behind those efforts were fundamentally correct. At the level of communication the language of Scholasticism has become increasingly alien to contemporary Catholics. We need to find an alternative approach which can faithfully transpose the achievements of the past. As I hope this paper demonstrates categories of meaning can provide rich resources for such a transposition, despite the difficulties once encountered. As such it may be timely to further explore further the contributions such a transposition may make to theological understanding.

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⁶⁷ For the classic exposition of his «hellenization» thesis see A. HARNACK, *Outlines of the History of Dogma*, trans. Edwin Mitchell, London, 1893. For Lonergan's critique of its modern restatement by Leslie Dewart see B. LONERGAN, «The Dehellenization of Dogma» in W. RYAN – B. TYRRELL (eds), *A Second Collection*, Philadelphia, 1974, 11-32.

⁶⁸ See N. ORMEROD, «Vatican II: Continuity or discontinuity?», for a full account of this argument which takes in the positions of Newman, MacIntyre and Lonergan.

SUMMARY

The work of Edward Schillebeeckx on the Eucharist was an early attempt to transpose traditional theological categories into the categories of meaning. In this paper I shall expand on this theme by drawing of the categories of meaning provided by Bernard Lonergan in *Method in Theology*. I briefly review earlier work of my own on the use of categories of meaning in relation to a theology of revelation. I shall then consider how traditional Trinitarian and Christological theologies would take shape under such a reframing. I shall then consider how such a transposition would affect our understanding of the Church and sacraments. I conclude by suggesting that the time is ripe for a large scale reframing of theological themes drawing upon Lonergan's account of meaning.

L'opera di Edward Schillebeeckx sull'eucaristia presenta un precoce tentativo di trasposizione delle categorie tradizionali della teologia nelle categorie della significazione. L'articolo sviluppa il tema riferendosi alle categorie della significazione esposte da Bernard Lonergan in *Method of Theology*. Esamino rapidamente una mia precedente proposta sull'uso delle categorie della significazione nell'ambito della teologia della rivelazione. Voglio poi come la teologia trinitaria e cristologica tradizionale potrebbe essere rinnovata in un simile quadro. Considero quindi come questa stessa trasposizione riguarda anche la nostra comprensione della Chiesa e dei sacramenti. Termino suggerendo che ha maturato il tempo per una ripresa di temi teologici a larga scala sotto la luce della proposta lonerganiana sulla significazione.